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Who Takes Care of Me?

For the daughter holding up aging parents,
kids, and a job — and running on fumes.

You're caring for everyone. No one is caring for you.

The appointments, the meds, the 6 a.m. worry calls, the sibling who "can't get away," the kids who still need you, the job that doesn't stop. You are the one who shows up. And you are quietly falling apart — exhausted past sleep, resentful, and then crushed by guilt for feeling resentful.

Here's the hard truth nobody says to a caregiver: this is not noble suffering. It's a slow-motion collapse, and a collapsed you can't care for anyone. You are also grieving — mourning a parent who is still alive, watching them slip while you hold everything together. That's called anticipatory grief, and it is brutal, and it is real.

This isn't a "self-care, take a bath" pamphlet. It's a tactical plan to get something back into your own tank and to make other people carry their share — with the exact words to make them do it.

THE NON-NEGOTIABLE

You cannot pour from an empty cup — and right now yours is bone dry. Taking care of you is not stealing from them. It's the only thing that lets you keep going without breaking.

STEP 1

The burnout check

Caregiver burnout creeps. Tick what's been true the last month. This isn't weakness — it's the cost of carrying too much, alone, for too long.

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| ☐ Exhausted in a way sleep doesn't touch | ☐ Isolated — nobody gets it |
| ☐ Resentful — then instantly guilty for it | ☐ Grieving them while they're still here |
| ☐ Dreading the next call or visit | ☐ Numb, just going through motions |
| ☐ Haven't been to my own doctor in ages | ☐ "If I stop, it all collapses" |
| ☐ Snapping at the people I love | ☐ Running on caffeine, sugar, sheer will |
| ☐ Crying in the car or the bathroom | ☐ Forgetting things, foggy, short-fused |

READ THIS

Several of these is not "I'm failing." It's "I'm one person doing a three-person job with no relief." The fix isn't to try harder. It's to carry less. Start on the next page.

STEP 2

The weekly cup-filling protocol

You won't get a vacation. You can get small, scheduled, non-negotiable refills. Put these on the calendar like they're *their* appointments — because you matter just as much:

- 1 **15 minutes a day that are yours.** A walk, a closed door, a coffee that's still hot. Same time daily. Guard it like a med dose — because it is one.

- 2 **One respite block a week.** 2–4 hours where someone else covers — a sibling, a friend, a paid aide, an adult day program. Book it in advance, every week.

- 3 **One appointment for YOU a month.** The doctor, dentist, or therapist you keep skipping. You schedule everyone else's. Schedule your own.

- 4 **Sleep is medicine, not a luxury.** Protect a hard bedtime. A wrecked, sleep-deprived caregiver makes mistakes and gets sick. Rest is part of the job.

- 5 **Drop one thing off the list weekly.** Delegate it, pay for it, or let it be "good enough." Groceries delivered, a cleaner once a month, a meal that's just fine.

STEP 3

Make them carry their share

Family doesn't step up because you make it look handled. They will keep letting you drown until you assign the work — specifically, out loud. Use these word for word:

“ **TO THE SIBLING WHO "CAN'T"**

I need you to own one regular thing — not help when asked, own it. Pick: Tuesdays, the pharmacy runs, or the bills. Which one?

“ **WHEN THEY OFFER VAGUELY**

You said let you know — so here it is. I need you to take Mom to her Thursday appointment this month. Can you?

“ **SAYING NO TO MORE**

I'm at capacity. I can't add anything else right now without something breaking.

“ **ON PAID HELP / RESPITE**

Looking into an aide or respite care isn't giving up — it's what makes this sustainable. Let's split the cost or use her funds for it.

“ **CALLING THE FAMILY MEETING**

I can't be the only one doing this anymore. Here's the full list of what it takes each week. We're dividing it today.

SAY IT FLAT

No apologizing, no softening it into a question they can dodge. Name the specific job, name who, name when. Vague asks get vague nothing.

Caregiver guilt vs the truth

The guilt lies to you on a loop. Trade each lie for what's actually true:

THE GUILT

"Resting means I don't care enough."

THE TRUTH

Rest is what keeps me able to care at all. A burned-out caregiver helps no one.

THE GUILT

"Getting help is abandoning them."

THE TRUTH

More hands means better care for them — and a me who isn't breaking down.

THE GUILT

"Resenting this makes me a bad daughter."

THE TRUTH

Resentment under this much load is normal. It's a signal to share the weight, not a character flaw.

THE GUILT

"I should be able to do this alone."

THE TRUTH

Nobody should. Caregiving is a team sport. Doing it solo isn't strength — it's a setup to fail.

You're a person, not just a caregiver.

Read these on the heavy days. They're true:

- My needs don't disappear because theirs are bigger.
- Asking for help is strategy, not weakness.
- I can love them deeply and still need a break from caring for them.
- Taking care of me *is* part of taking care of them.
- I am allowed to have a life that is also mine.

You don't have to do this alone. In the U.S., call your local **Area Agency on Aging** (eldercare.acl.gov or 1-800-677-1116) for respite options, in-home help, and what your parent may qualify for. For caregiver support, the Family Caregiver Alliance and a quick search for "respite care + your area" can lift real weight off you this week.

You can't set yourself on fire to keep them warm.

Fifteen minutes a day. One block of relief a week. One appointment kept for you. One job handed off — with the words to make it stick. You are allowed to be cared for too. Put yourself back on the list. You were always supposed to be on it.

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